Technically speaking, it was a case of ‘murder’, but the assassination of a world leader who was set to return to power in the world’s largest democracy was not just a case of ‘murder’. Kaarthikeyan was well aware of that. Yet his denial to look beyond was inconceivable. He was once again more than happy to offer evening tiffin served at Malligai than discuss the course of the investigation. He might have thought it was not obligatory on his part to answer certain questions, but the world was raising them. Charu Lata Joshi from *India Today* raised the issue of what prevented the investigators from probing leads directing them to a link between Rajiv Gandhi’s assassins and some DMK members. Or why intelligence reports exposing an international angle to the conspiracy remained unexplored. And, very importantly, why ‘portions of the case diaries [were] deleted from investigation records when presented at the time of production of the assassins before the court’.[4]

According to Joshi’s story, Kaarthikeyan had written to his director, Vijay Karan, that certain case diaries recorded on 23 June 1991, be expunged from the records. These diaries contained a statement made by Thomas Charles, an independent witness, on 29 May 1991, eight days after Rajiv Gandhi’s assassination, to Kanth, Verma and Ragothaman. On the basis of photo identification, Charles had singled out Sivarasan, one of the key conspirators in the assassination case, as also being one of those involved in the assassination of EPRLF leader K. Padmanabha in Madras on 19 June 1990. Escaping to the coast after Padmanabha was killed, the LTTE hit squad had hijacked Charles’s car the same night.[5]

But Kaarthikeyan refused to pay any heed to the controversy as he saw it as more of an ego clash between some officers. Reportedly, Vijay Karan wrote to Kaarthikeyan after some officers took exception and said the matter should have been referred to the CBI’s legal adviser, which was not done. But the SIT’s investigations had confirmed the link between the two assassinations and had been very well appreciated by Kaarthikeyan. So how crucial was Charles’s statement that Sivarasan was the same person who had made off with his Maruti van, implicating him in Padmanabha’s assassination? He was an ‘independent witness’, and therefore his statement